Lesson 32: Pronunciation: Reduced Words in Sentences; -Ed Endings

English Stage 1 (B1) · Unit 4: Education and Creativity

Adapted from Speaking, Listening and Pronunciation Projects for ELLs - Intermediate Level by Brittany Zemlick, Grossmont College (CC BY 4.0): 4.3: Review - Reduced Words in Sentences; 4.4: -Ed Endings.

In this lesson

First you review reduced words: small structure words like "and", "a" and "to" that we say quickly. Then you learn the three ways to say the -ed ending of regular past tense verbs, /t/, /d/ and /ɪd/, and how to link it to the next word. You practice with the story of Gillian Lynne.

Learning goals

After this lesson you should be able to:

- Hear and write the small structure words in a fast sentence.
- Choose the correct -ed sound (/t/, /d/ or /ɪd/) from the last sound of the verb.
- Feel the difference between voiced and unvoiced sounds.
- Link -ed endings to the next word.
- Describe the important events of a life in the past tense.

Key language

Word or phrase	Meaning in simple English	Example
structure word (reduced word)	a small grammar word, like and, a, an, in, to; we say it quickly and quietly	Gillian and I had lunch one day.
final sound	the last sound you say in a word (not the last letter)	"judge" ends in the sound /ʤ/
voiced sound	a sound that makes your throat vibrate	/n/ as in "explain"
unvoiced (voiceless) sound	a sound with no vibration in your throat	/k/ as in "talk"
/t/ ending	-ed after an unvoiced sound	talked, watched, helped
/d/ ending	-ed after a voiced sound	explained, bothered, turned
/ɪd/ ending (also written /əd/)	-ed after /t/ or /d/; it adds a syllable	needed, started, graduated
linking	joining the end of a word to the next word	I lived in Thailand. (live-din)

Word or phrase	Meaning in simple English	Example
timeline	a line that shows the important events of a life in order	Brittany's timeline

Rules and explanations

Reduced words (review)

- In a sentence, structure words such as **and, a, an, in, to** are usually not stressed. We say them quickly and quietly, so they are hard to hear.
- For example, **to** often sounds like /tə/, and **and** like /ən/ or /n/ (see Lesson 28).

The three -ed sounds

The -ed sound depends on the **last sound** of the base verb, not the last letter.

Last sound of the verb	Say -ed as	Book examples
/t/ or /d/ (need, start)	/ɪd/, an extra syllable	needed, started, waited
unvoiced: /f/, /k/, /p/, /s/, /ʧ/ as in "watch", /ʃ/ as in "push", /θ/ as in "think"	/t/	talked, looked, pushed, asked, watched, helped, dressed
voiced: /b/, /g/, /ʤ/ as in "judge", /l/, /m/, /n/, /ŋ/ as in "sing", /r/, /ð/ as in "breathe", /v/, /z/, and all vowels	/d/	explained, bothered, sobbed, roamed, believed, judged, filled, enjoyed

- Only /ɪd/ adds a syllable. "Talked" has one syllable; "need·ed" has two.
- Look at the sound, not the spelling: "believe" ends in the letter e but the sound /v/, so "believed" ends in /d/. "Enjoy" ends in a vowel sound, so "enjoyed" ends in /d/.

Voiced or unvoiced?

- Put your hand on your throat. A vibration at the end of the word = voiced. No vibration = unvoiced. "Unvoiced" and "voiceless" mean the same thing.
- Careful: in Video Questions 1 the book lists /p/ as voiced and /b/ as unvoiced. This is a mistake: /p/ is unvoiced and /b/ is voiced, as the book's own table shows. Exercise 4 below is corrected.

Linking -ed endings

- If the next word begins with a **vowel**, the -ed is clear. Link it: I lived in Thailand. (sounds like live-din)
- If the next word begins with **/t/ or /d/**, the -ed is difficult to hear: Tommy looked tired. (sounds like look-tired)

> **Note for Arabic speakers** - Many learners say every -ed as an extra syllable ("talk-ed"). Add a syllable only after /t/ and /d/. - Arabic has no /p/ sound, so "helped" can sound like "helbed". Keep /p/ unvoiced (no vibration), then add a /t/ sound.

Practice

Audio clips. The book's recordings for this lesson are on your computer, in the folder `E:\personal-tutor\materials\library\esl-b1-speaking\attachments\04.04-ed-endings\`. You can also play them on the original web page (see "Watch online").

1. Reduced words. Listen to the TED Talk from 15:14 to 15:38 (see "Watch online"). Write the missing structure words. Gillian (1) ____ I had lunch one day. I said, "How did you get to be (2) ____ dancer?" It was interesting. When she was (3) ____ school, she was really hopeless. And the school, in the '30s, wrote (4) ____ her parents (5) ____ said, "We think Gillian has (6) ____ learning disorder." She couldn't concentrate; she was fidgeting. I think now they'd say she had ADHD. Wouldn't you? But this was the 1930s, (7) ____ ADHD hadn't been invented at this point. It wasn't (8) ____ available condition. People weren't aware they could have that.

2. Which sound? Play `Rules_to_Remember_-_ed_endings.m4a`. Listen to the words from the TED Talk. Do you hear /d/, /t/ or /ɪd/ at the end? Circle the sound for each group. a. needed, started, graduated b. talked, watched, helped c. explained, bothered, turned

3. Sort the verbs. Play `Practice_-Ed_endings.m4a`. Listen and repeat the words in the table: /t/ talked, watched, helped; /d/ explained, bothered, turned; /ɪd/ needed, started, graduated, founded. Then change these words to the past tense, add them to the correct column and say them aloud. dance, invent, cook, vacuum (the book spells it "vaccum"), marry, wash, join, create, live, belong, end

4. Watch the video "Elemental English: -Ed Endings" (see "Watch online"). Then answer. Video Questions 1: 1-3. What is the final sound you hear when you say *walked*? *smelled*? *visited*? (/d/, /t/ or /ɪd/)

4. When a sound is voiced (like /v/, /g/, /b/, or /d/), you ... don't feel / feel a vibration in your throat.
5. When a sound is unvoiced (like /f/, /k/, /p/, or /t/), you ... don't feel / feel a vibration in your throat.
6. "Unvoiced" and "voiceless" mean the same thing. True or false? 7-10. Is the final sound voiced or unvoiced? 7 vow, 8 fake, 9 tape, 10 gaze

Video Questions 2: Choose /d/, /t/ or /ɪd/: vowed, faked, gazed, taped, decided, waited.

5. Present or past? Listen and circle the sentence you hear. Ask your tutor to read, for each number, the sentence in the book's answer (Answer key 5 of this guide) without telling you which one. If the tutor cannot see this guide, it can choose a or b and tell you at the end. Check your answers. Next, ask the tutor to read both sentences in each pair, and repeat them. Last, you read a or b, and the tutor guesses which one you read.

1. We always (a) bother / (b) bothered other students.
2. I (a) talk / (b) talked to the doctor every day.
3. You (a) turned / (b) turn in your homework.
4. They (a) started / (b) start to dance.
5. I (a) study / (b) studied every night.
6. You (a) work / (b) worked too much.

7. I (a) need / (b) needed to speak with him.
8. The doctor (a) turned / (b) turns on the radio.
9. You (a) look / (b) looked tired.
10. I (a) live / (b) lived in Thailand.

6. Record: linking. Read each sentence and link the -ed ending to the next word. Record yourself with your phone and listen back.

- Gillian's mother talked to the doctor.
- She explained that Gillian was having problems in school.
- Gillian bothered other students.
- She turned in her homework late.
- The doctor turned on the radio.
- She started to dance.

7. Talk about a timeline. Brittany's timeline:

Year	Important events
2006	graduated from university
2006-2007	worked on a farm
2008-2009	got hired to teach English in Thailand and learned some Thai
2010-2011	applied for and got accepted to an MEd in TESOL course and moved to England
2014-2016	started working in Bogota, Colombia and learned some Spanish

a. Tell Brittany's life story aloud with the correct -ed endings. Start: "She graduated from university in 2006. Then she worked on a farm from 2006 to 2007..." b. Draw your own timeline. Make a phone video of yourself describing the important events in your life. Watch it and check your -ed endings.

8. Listening practice. Play `Summary_of_Gillian_Lynne_Story_.m4a`. Listen to the summary of the story and write the missing words. Number 1 is done.

1. Gillian's mother **talked** to the doctor for 20 minutes. 2-4. She ____ that Gillian ____ other students and she ____ in her homework late.

5. Then the doctor told Gillian he ____ to speak to her mother privately.
6. Before he left the room, the doctor ____ on the radio.
7. After they left the room, the doctor and Gillian's mom ____ Gillian.
8. Gillian immediately ____ to dance.
9. They all ____ to move in order to think. 10-11. She ____ from the Royal Ballet School, and ____ the Gillian Lynne Dance Company.

12. She ____ create some very successful musical theater productions.

9. Record: -ed endings (24 points). Find the "Summary" at the end of your printed lesson. Mark each -ed verb /t/, /d/ or /ɪd/. Practice, then record yourself reading the whole summary. Give yourself one point for each -ed ending you say correctly and one point for each -ed ending you link correctly to the next word.

Speak with your tutor

- "Read sentence a or b from each pair in my list. I will tell you which one I heard. Then I will read, and you guess."
- "Say a regular verb. I will say the past tense and tell you if the -ed is /t/, /d/ or /ɪd/. Tell me if I am right."
- "Ask me about the important events in my life, year by year. I will answer in the past tense. Correct my verbs."
- "Read the Gillian Lynne summary slowly. Stop at each -ed verb and ask me which sound it has."

Read aloud

- talked, watched, helped (one syllable each)
- ex·PLAINED, BOTH·ered, turned
- NEED·ed, START·ed, GRAD·u·at·ed, FOUND·ed
- I lived in Thailand. (live-din) (↘)
- Tommy looked tired. (look-tired) (↘)
- Gillian bothered other students. (↘)
- The doctor turned on the radio. (↘)
- She started to dance. (↘)

Watch online

- TED Talk "Do Schools Kill Creativity?" (15:14 to 15:38 for exercise 1): https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=iG9CE55wbtY&t=914s (the book's link: https://www.ted.com/talks/sir_ken_robinson_do_schools_kill_creativity)
- Elemental English: -Ed Endings: https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=j32SurxnE4s
- Original web page of this lesson, with the audio clips: https://human.libretexts.org/Bookshelves/Languages/English_as_a_Second_Language/Book%3A_Speaking_Listening_and_Pronunciation_Projects_for_ELLs_-_Intermediate_Level_(Zemlick)/04%3A_Education_and_Creativity/4.04%3A_-_Ed_Endings

Answer key

1. (book) 1 and, 2 a, 3 in, 4 to, 5 and, 6 a, 7 and, 8 an. For 3, the book's answer is "in", but its transcript of the same part in Lesson 33 has "at school". Both are correct English.

2. (book) a /ɪd/, b /t/, c /d/.

3. /t/: danced, cooked, washed. /d/: vacuumed, married, joined, lived, belonged. /ɪd/: invented, created, ended. (Last sounds: dance /s/, cook /k/, wash /ʃ/; vacuum /m/, marry a vowel, join /n/, live /v/, belong /ŋ/; invent and create /t/; end /d/.)

4. Video Questions 1: 1 /t/, 2 /d/, 3 /ɪd/, 4 feel, 5 don't feel, 6 true, 7 voiced (a vowel sound), 8 unvoiced (/k/), 9 unvoiced (/p/), 10 voiced (/z/). Video Questions 2: vowed /d/, faked /t/, gazed /d/, taped /t/, decided /ɪd/, waited /ɪd/.

5. (book answer sheet) 1 b, 2 a, 3 a, 4 b, 5 b, 6 a, 7 b, 8 a, 9 b, 10 a. Remember: the -ed is easy to hear before a vowel (bothered other, turned in, studied every, turned on, lived in) and hard to hear before /t/ (talked to, started to, worked too, needed to, looked tired).

6. talked to: talk-to (hard to hear). explained /d/. bothered other: bother-dother. turned in: turn-din. turned on: turn-don. started to: the ending is hard to hear.

7. (example answer; the first two sentences are the book's) She graduated from university in 2006. Then she worked on a farm from 2006 to 2007. In 2008 she got hired to teach English in Thailand and learned some Thai. In 2010 she applied for and got accepted to an MEd in TESOL course and moved to England. In 2014 she started working in Bogota, Colombia. -ed sounds: graduated /ɪd/, worked /t/, hired /d/, learned /d/, applied /d/, accepted /ɪd/, moved /d/, started /ɪd/.

8. (book) 2 explained, 3 bothered, 4 turned, 5 needed, 6 turned, 7 watched, 8 started, 9 needed, 10 graduated, 11 founded, 12 helped.

9. talked /t/, explained /d/, bothered /d/, turned /d/, needed /ɪd/, turned /d/, watched /t/, started /ɪd/, needed /ɪd/, graduated /ɪd/, founded /ɪd/, helped /t/.

My notes